SlabMetrics

Decision intelligence for sports card investors

Internal Working Document

Not for external distribution

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How to Use This Document

This is a working document, not a pitch. Its job is to make our thinking visible to ourselves, force us to commit to specific hypotheses, and create a record we can revisit as evidence comes in.

Cadence

- Revisit monthly — first weekend of each month, together, ~90 minutes.
- Full rewrite at each 30/60/90-day milestone of the Decision-Logging Experiment.
- Don't share externally in this form. An outside-facing version (memo + deck) gets built once we have validated evidence in months 4-6.

Open Questions

Each section ends with explicit open questions. The point of this document is not to answer them prematurely — it's to keep them visible so we work on them deliberately.

1. Executive Summary

SlabMetrics is a decision intelligence platform for people who treat sports cards as a financial asset rather than purely as a hobby. The product will combine fast comp lookup with one or more decision intelligence features — analytical tools that help investor-minded collectors make better buy, sell, and submission decisions, with the explicit goal of improving their return on investment over time. Specific features (such as a buy/hold/sell recommendation engine, a grading expected-value calculator, or other analytical capabilities) will be selected based on findings from the 90-day decision-logging experiment and customer research.

The opportunity exists because the dominant tools in the sports card analytics space (Card Ladder, Market Movers, CollX, Alt) are positioned as either lookup utilities or generalist trackers — none have built a decision intelligence layer that connects comp data to actionable buy/sell/submit decisions.

This wedge hypothesis is based on competitive analysis and informal conversation with a small number of card-investor users; it has not yet been validated with structured customer research.

Current Stage

- Pre-revenue. Pre-launch. Kain Kim is actively building the prototype and underlying data infrastructure; a functional prototype currently exists as a single-file HTML application, with data-layer work (eBay and 130point integration, comp ingestion pipeline) underway.
- Two-founder team. Founders' agreement signed (May 2026, vesting 4 years / 1-year cliff).
- eBay developer program: sandbox keys obtained; production access pending compliance work.
- Decision-logging experiment underway, with both Kain Kim (as a beginner card investor) and Carson Froy participating. Each founder is contributing $500 of personal capital for the 90-day experiment; Carson's existing ~$3k portfolio is kept personal.
- Early conversations underway with prospective friends-and-family investors regarding small pre-seed checks. No capital has been committed; terms, instrument, and timing remain open. Decisions to formalize any raise will be deferred until after the LLC is formed and the wedge feature is validated through customer research.
- Sports card market research is Carson Froy's primary current focus. Carson has attended approximately 8 sports card shows prior to SlabMetrics and is now formalizing his show attendance as structured customer research — surveying investor-minded collectors, mapping current pain points, understanding tool usage patterns, and building dealer/collector relationships. Kain Kim is joining in-person card show attendance for the first time to broaden the research footprint and develop firsthand exposure to the investor community. Both founders are also starting engagement in online card-investor

communities (Discord servers, card-Twitter, relevant subreddits). Specific venues, survey design, and target counts to be developed.

Near-Term Goals (6 Months)

1. Complete the 90-day decision-logging experiment, producing a ranked list of signals and a validated wedge.
2. Conduct 30+ structured customer interviews with non-friend card investors.
3. Ship a minimum-viable comp lookup plus the Buy/Hold/Sell Recommendation Engine (the v1 wedge feature, per Section 4.2).
4. Establish the SlabMetrics brand on social media at the Phase 1 (light-touch) level — brand presence, credibility, and audience-building, not a full content/media engine. Gated: this work begins only once the minimum-viable comp lookup and at least one decision intelligence feature are live and functioning effectively. Carson leads brand identity and content strategy; Kain supports with digital distribution. The transition to a Phase 2 heavy content engine for hobbyist-to-investor conversion is governed by the gate condition in Section 3.3.
5. Acquire first 20 paying users at a price point ≥ Card Ladder's.

2. The Problem We're Solving

2.1 What Card Investors Actually Do

A card investor makes regular decisions of this form:

- Should I buy this card at this price? (comp lookup, grade verification, scarcity check)
- Is this raw card worth submitting for grading, and what's the expected return? (grade prediction + EV math)
- Should I sell this card now or hold? (price trend, upcoming catalysts, opportunity cost)
- What players or sets should I be paying attention to? (market discovery, momentum, signal monitoring)

2.2 Why Current Tools Fall Short

Card Ladder

Strongest existing competitor for the investor segment. Provides indices, portfolio tracking, and comp lookup. Pricing approximately $200/year for the standard tier.

Verify current pricing.

- Strength: established data, multi-year history, large card database.
- Weakness (per informal user conversations): comp lookup requires multiple clicks and searches; interface is dense and lookup-oriented rather than decision-oriented.
- Weakness (our analysis): does not connect comp data to actionable decisions. Card Ladder is a lookup and tracking tool, not a decision intelligence layer — it shows users prices and trends but does not synthesize that data into specific buy, sell, or submission recommendations or expected-value math.

Market Movers / Sports Card Investor

Focused on price movement alerts and trend identification. Useful for active traders but less comprehensive for portfolio management.

- Strength: real-time price alert infrastructure; brand built around active trading and timely signals; content ecosystem (YouTube, podcast) supports user education.
- Weakness (our analysis): alert-driven UX favors active flippers over portfolio-holding investors; does not synthesize comp data and grading EV math into specific decision recommendations; less useful where the question is buy/sell/submit rather than price-movement notification.

CollX

Primarily a collection tracker with photo-identification. Strong on the hobbyist UX side. Light on investor-grade analytics. Free tier is well-funded.

- Strength: free entry point with strong photo-identification onboarding; large user base; mobile-first experience; community provides scale of input data.
- Weakness (our analysis): hobbyist-default framing; collection tracking is the primary product, decision intelligence is absent; community-sourced pricing is noisier and less authoritative than sold-listings data; the free tier sets a low willingness-to-pay benchmark for users who later look for serious tools.

Alt

Asset-class framing for cards. Marketplace + portfolio + analytics. Premium positioning. Targets the high-end collector/investor segment.

- Strength: premium brand and design language; trusted by high-end collectors as an asset-class platform; vertically integrated (marketplace + analytics + portfolio).
- Weakness (our analysis): marketplace-and-portfolio focus rather than a decision intelligence layer; positioned toward high-end cards (commonly $1k+) where our beachhead ($50–$500 modern graded) is underserved; pricing and access tier likely too steep for the mid-portfolio investor we target.

2.3 The Specific Pain We're Targeting

We are not building a better collection tracker, a better marketplace, or a better card-database. We are building the answer to one question:

> **Our Core Question**
> When a card investor is about to make a buy, sell, or submission decision — how do we make that decision more efficient, more accurate, and more informed, with the clarity of a trusted mentor walking them through it?

SlabMetrics is being built as a decision intelligence platform in a way no current competitor is — not as a data tool that helps users make decisions, but as a tool whose primary unit of output is the decision itself. No existing card analytics product is structured this way, though several competitors have decision-adjacent features (Market Movers' Intelligence Reports, Card Ladder's indices, Alt's analytics). The distinction is that SlabMetrics is built around the decision; they are built around the data.

This framing emerged from this strategy work in May 2026 and supersedes the broader 'sports card intelligence platform' framing we started with.

Open Questions — Problem

- How widely is the 'investor-minded' identity actually held by card collectors? Is it 5% of the collector base, 25%, or 50%?
- Has the 'cards as investment' thesis recovered from the 2022-2023 cooling, or is it still in a winter? Verify current state with recent data and dealer conversations.

- What share of investor-minded collectors currently pay for any analytics tool? What share would?

3. Customer

3.1 Primary Customer Profile (Working Hypothesis)

SlabMetrics is built for investors first. Our v1 customer is not a casual hobbyist who happens to think about value, and not a fan who occasionally flips. Our v1 customer is someone for whom buying, selling, and grading cards is a deliberate financial activity, even if it is also fun. Every product decision should sharpen the tool for that person, not soften it for a broader audience.

> **Who We Build For**
> The serious sports card investor — the person who treats buy, sell, and submission decisions as financial decisions, and who is actively looking for tools that make those decisions sharper. Hobbyists are welcome; the product is not built around them.

Our v1 target customer:

- Self-identifies as an 'investor' or 'serious flipper,' not primarily as a fan or rip-pack hobbyist.
- Makes buy/sell decisions at least monthly.
- Currently uses Card Ladder, Market Movers, 130point, or a spreadsheet to make decisions.
- Modern sports — basketball, football, and baseball are the v1 focus. Baseball is included to broaden product depth and addressable market; both founders are concurrently developing baseball domain expertise through active card acquisition and decision-logging.
- Comfortable spending $20-50/month on tools that demonstrably improve returns or save time.

This profile is a working hypothesis based on competitive analysis and instinct. It will be tested and refined through 30+ structured customer interviews in months 1-3.

3.2 Who This Is Not For (v1)

- Pure hobbyists with no investment framing. Possible to convert later; not the wedge.
- Vintage-only collectors. Different data sources, different community.
- High-end auction-house buyers ($10k+ per card). Important to serve eventually, but their workflow runs through different venues (Goldin, Heritage) and we won't have that data on day one.
- Pure dealers and breakers with inventory management needs. Adjacent but distinct workflow.

3.3 The Conversion Arc

A secondary thesis: serious hobbyists with portfolios in the $1k-$5k range and growing financial curiosity are a natural conversion target. The mechanism for conversion is a heavy content/media engine — social media, video, written content, educational material that teaches hobbyists how investors think and what investors do differently. The model is what Sports Card Investor did with Market Movers: build the audience, teach the framing, convert into product usage. The execution sequence is deliberately two-phase:

6. Phase 1 (v1 and through validation): build and perfect the decision intelligence platform for the investor audience. Content during this phase is light and incidental — supports brand presence and credibility, but is not a core company activity.
7. Phase 2 (post-gate): the heavy content/media engine activates as a core company activity, targeting hobbyist-to-investor conversion. Gate condition: at least 50 paying investor users with demonstrated retention/engagement evidence of product-market fit, AND both founders agree the investor product is delivering real value. Without meeting both criteria, Phase 2 does not activate — content stays light.

Open Questions — Customer

- Of the customers we eventually talk to, what share already self-identify as investors vs. need to be 'converted'?
- What's the smallest portfolio size where SlabMetrics is genuinely useful? (Affects pricing and TAM math.)
- How do these customers currently discover new tools? Card-Twitter? Reddit? Trade shows? YouTube? Determines GTM.

4. The Wedge

4.1 Positioning Statement

Working Positioning
SlabMetrics is the decision intelligence platform for serious sports card investors. The primary unit of output is the decision itself — buy, hold, sell, submit, or pass — not the data behind it. Card Ladder is a lookup tool. CollX is a tracker. Market Movers surfaces price movements. SlabMetrics synthesizes comps, grading EV, and other analytical signals into specific, actionable recommendations.

4.2 The Wedge Feature

SlabMetrics is committing to a single wedge feature for v1: the Buy/Hold/Sell Recommendation Engine described below. We are not running a portfolio of wedge candidates. Instead, we are testing a portfolio of signals inside one wedge. The 90-day decision-logging experiment is structured to identify which of the five candidate signals (prediction markets, player injury, season phase, pop report changes, frequency-of-sale velocity) carry real predictive value. If at least one or two signals validate, the wedge is built around them. If none validate, we revise the signal set and re-test rather than switching to a different wedge entirely. Failure criterion (defined now so it can't be argued away later): Candidate A has failed if, after 90 days of decision logging, no candidate signal demonstrates predictive value above naive baselines for the cards in the experiment portfolio. Specifically: a signal is considered to have predictive value only if buys made primarily on that signal show better net returns over 30-day and 60-day horizons than the average across all logged buys, by a margin that is not explained by sample noise. If zero of the five signals clear this bar, the wedge is deemed to have failed and the response is to revise the signal set and re-test, not to declare partial success.

Candidate A — Buy/Hold/Sell Recommendation Engine

- What: For each card in a user's collection or watchlist, produce a specific recommendation — Buy, Hold, Consider Selling, Sell — derived from the synthesis of multiple market and contextual signals. The output is the decision itself with the reasoning shown, not just data for the user to interpret.
- Candidate signals (to be validated during the 90-day decision-logging experiment): prediction market movements (Kalshi / PolyMarket player-event odds for awards, milestones, postseason outcomes), player injury status, season phase (preseason, regular season, postseason), pop report changes (PSA population shifts indicating scarcity dynamics), and frequency-of-sale velocity (how often the card is trading, not just at what price). Which signals actually carry predictive value is the empirical question the experiment is designed to answer.
- Wedge: the wedge is the synthesis of multiple signals into a specific actionable decision per card. No incumbent card analytics tool currently produces this kind of per-card

buy/hold/sell recommendation — Card Ladder shows trends, Market Movers shows alerts, neither synthesizes inputs into a decision. This is the clearest expression of the decision intelligence framing.

- Defensibility: the harder the signal stack to replicate, the harder the wedge to copy. Prediction market integration alone is novel; combining it with pop report dynamics and sale velocity creates a synthesis no current competitor has assembled. Founder-team adjacency to analytical workflows (Kain's EdgeIQ infrastructure for prediction-market data, Carson's domain context on injury and season effects) supports the build.

Validation risk: the entire wedge depends on at least one or two of the candidate signals actually carrying predictive value in real card price movement. If the 90-day experiment shows none of the signals predict returns better than naive baselines (e.g., a 30-day moving average), the wedge has failed per the Section 4.2 failure criterion. The response is to revise the signal set and re-test, not to switch wedges — there is no Plan B wedge.

4.3 What We're Explicitly Not Leading With

Not 'trend forecasting'

Forecasting individual card prices well is a hard quantitative problem. Card Ladder, with years of data, hasn't cracked it convincingly. Leading with 'we forecast trends' makes a promise we can't yet keep. We may add forecasting features later if we discover signals that genuinely work.

Not 'AI grading'

Phone-photo-based grading prediction with PSA-grader accuracy is not achievable with current consumer imagery and general-purpose vision models. Framing matters: 'submission candidate scorer' yes, 'AI grader' no.

Not 'more features for less money'

Pricing below Card Ladder signals 'cheap option,' which is the opposite of what an investor audience wants. We will price at or above Card Ladder once feature parity is reached on the comp side and we have a unique decision-intelligence feature.

Open Questions — Wedge

- Which of the five candidate signals (or other signals that may emerge from customer research) actually predict card price movements? To be answered by Day 90 of the decision-logging experiment per the Section 4.2 failure criterion.
- Can we ship a credible v1 of the Buy/Hold/Sell Recommendation Engine within 90 days of validation while comp data infrastructure is still being built?
- Are there signals we haven't considered that customer research surfaces? The five candidate signals are a starting set, not an exhaustive one.

5. Product

5.1 What Exists Today

A single-file HTML application built by Kain in Q1-Q2 2026. Pages include:

- Browse by league/sport
- Market analysis page with CardIQ index, top movers, volume by sport
- Collection management with grade filtering and value sorting
- Watchlist
- AI card grading (currently a marketing label — to be reframed and re-built as the Submission Candidate Scorer)
- Player market pages

Current state is prototype-level. No real-time data integrations. No backend or user accounts. No payment system. Designed for design iteration and stakeholder demos, not for users.

5.2 v1 Scope (6-Month Goal)

Build the minimum credible version of the product to acquire first paying users.

Must-Haves

- User accounts and authentication.
- Comp lookup powered by real eBay + 130point data (sold and active listings), scoped to basketball, football, and baseball cards in v1, offered as the free tier of the product. Other sports added in later releases.
- The Buy/Hold/Sell Recommendation Engine as defined in Section 4.2, with at least one validated signal informing recommendations. This is the paid (Pro tier) product.
- Subscription billing (Stripe) for the Pro tier; free tier requires only a user account.
- Basic collection/watchlist tied to user accounts.
- Mobile-responsive (most card collectors browse comps on phones).

Explicitly Out of Scope for v1

- Additional decision intelligence features beyond the v1 wedge. Other features (submission decision engine, cross-venue arbitrage, position-sizing, catalyst calendar, etc.) are deferred to v2 or v3 until the v1 wedge has validated.
- Marketplace functionality. We do not facilitate buying/selling between users.
- Comprehensive multi-sport data. Modern basketball, football, and baseball are in v1. Soccer and other sports later. Vintage cards (pre-2000) will be present in the catalog at the identity level (name, year, set, card number) so users can search and find them, but no market analysis, comp lookup, or decision intelligence will be provided for vintage in

v1 — vintage searches return a clear 'not yet supported for analysis' message. Full vintage analytics is a future expansion.

- Tax/cost-basis reporting. High-value but high-complexity. Add when paying users request it.
- Auction-house integration (Goldin, Fanatics Collect, Heritage). Important eventually; not v1.

5.3 Build Sequence

8. Months 1-2: Data infrastructure (eBay production access, 130point integration, basic comp ingestion pipeline) — market data scoped to basketball, football, and baseball cards for v1. Card identity data (catalog records for search) includes vintage cards across these sports so users can find them, but no market data ingestion is performed for vintage. Other sports are out of scope for the v1 pipeline and will be added in later integration and infrastructure improvements. Customer interviews in parallel.
9. Months 2-3: Comp lookup v1 — the free tier product, with built-in limits (watchlist cap, 30-day history cap). Designed both as standalone value and as the top of the conversion funnel to the paid Buy/Hold/Sell Recommendation Engine.
10. Months 3-4: Buy/Hold/Sell Recommendation Engine v1, built around whichever signals the 90-day experiment validated.
11. Month 4: Closed beta with 10-15 hand-picked card investors. Iterate.
12. Months 5-6: Public launch with subscription. Goal: 20 paying users by end of month 6.

This sequence assumes one developer (Kain) working approximately half-time during the academic year and full-time during the summer break. Sequence will slip if classes intensify or if data access takes longer than expected.

Open Questions — Product

- Which validated signals from the 90-day experiment are most important to expose in the v1 product UI? Decision deadline: end of 90-day decision-logging experiment.

6. Market

6.1 What We Know

The sports card market saw an explosive run-up in 2020-2021, peaked, and has been mixed since. Some segments (modern basketball blue-chip rookies) have rebuilt; others remain well below 2021 highs. The investor-identity collector remains a real audience but is smaller and more skeptical than during the peak.

Market sizing for the sports card collectibles industry has been quoted in the low-to-mid single-digit billions of dollars annually, but methodology varies widely across sources. We are deliberately not using a specific top-down TAM number until we have a defensible bottom-up estimate.

6.2 Why Top-Down Sizing Doesn't Help Us Yet

At our stage, top-down market sizing ('the $X billion card collectibles industry') is a vanity number. What matters is bottom-up addressable market for our specific product:

- Approximately how many serious card investors exist in the US? (Order of magnitude estimate to be developed.)
- What share would pay for an analytics tool at our price point?
- What share would specifically switch from or adopt SlabMetrics?

These are the numbers we'll develop bottom-up over months 1-3 through customer interviews and competitive analysis (e.g., estimating Card Ladder's subscriber base from public signals).

6.3 Beachhead

Initial beachhead: investor-minded collectors of modern (post-2000) PSA-graded basketball, football, and baseball cards, primarily in the US, primarily English-speaking, primarily ages 25-45. Baseball coverage requires concurrent development of founder domain expertise, which is being addressed through active card acquisition and decision-logging.

This is narrow on purpose. Better to dominate a small clearly-defined slice and expand than to be the 47th choice for everyone.

Open Questions — Market

- Bottom-up estimate: how many people fit our target customer profile in the US? Reasonable methodology TBD.
- Has card investor sentiment recovered enough from the 2022-23 cooling to support a new paid tool? Or are we entering a contracting market?
- How big is Card Ladder's subscriber base? Any public or inferred signals?

7. Competitive Landscape

7.1 Direct Competitors

Capability	Card Ladder	Market Movers	CollX	Alt	130point	SlabMetrics (planned)
Sold-comp lookup	✓	✓	partial	partial	✓	✓
Collection / portfolio tracking	✓	✓	✓	✓	—	✓
Market indices / trend charts	✓	✓	—	✓	—	partial
Price alerts	partial	✓	—	—	—	✓
Pop report integration	partial	✓	—	—	—	✓
Prediction-market signal integration	—	—	—	—	—	✓
Per-card buy/hold/sell recommendations	—	—	—	—	—	✓ (the v1 wedge)
Synthesizes multiple signals into decisions	—	—	—	—	—	✓ (the v1 wedge)
Free tier with meaningful functionality	—	partial	✓	—	✓	✓
Marketplace / transactions	—	—	partial	✓	—	— (deliberately out of scope)

Pricing estimates are working figures and should be verified before any external use of this document.

7.2 Indirect Competitors

- eBay's own price-research tools (free, integrated, but rudimentary).
- PSA Set Registry (collection management for graded cards — focused on completionism, not investing).
- Card-Twitter analysts and Discord servers (free expertise; no tooling).
- Manual spreadsheets (still the most common way real investors track positions).

7.3 Honest Read on Our Position

We are entering a non-empty market against well-resourced incumbents. Our wedge has to be a real workflow advantage on at least one dimension, not just a UI refresh. The history of card-tool startups is mostly littered with 'cleaner UI' attempts that got copied by incumbents within a year.

Our credible angles are:

13. Decision-intelligence framing that no incumbent currently leads with.
14. Founder-team adjacency to analytical decision-making workflows more broadly — including comp analysis, expected-value modeling, and signal integration (Kain's EdgeIQ work on sports betting analytics and prediction-market data is one example).
15. Founder discipline on customer research and decision-logging that most incumbents skipped.

We do not yet have a defensible network effect, data moat, or distribution advantage. We need to develop at least one within 12-18 months.

Open Questions — Competition

- Is there a competitor we haven't seen yet — particularly something newer that targets the same investor segment?
- What's the realistic worst-case competitive response if we get traction? (Card Ladder ships a faster comp page in 90 days?)
- Are there potential acquirers we should be aware of from day one?

8. Go-to-Market

8.1 Founder Roles in GTM

- Carson: field marketing, card-show presence, brand identity, social media, community-building, dealer/collector relationships.
- Kain: digital acquisition (SEO, paid acquisition once it's worth running), content distribution online, product analytics.

8.2 Acquisition Channels (Prioritized)

Tier 1 — High-leverage, founder-fit

- Card-Twitter and r/sportscards content: occasional, light-touch technical analysis posts that demonstrate expertise (e.g., 'how prediction markets moved before LeBron's record'). Builds early credibility. The full brand presence and the eventual heavy content/media engine for hobbyist conversion are sequenced separately per Section 3.3.
- Direct outreach to micro-influencers in the card investor space (creators with 5k-50k followers who post analytically). Free product access for honest reviews.
- Trade shows (Carson's domain). Build brand presence; collect customer-research conversations; identify beta candidates.

Tier 2 — Worth testing once we have product

- YouTube partnerships with card investment content creators.
- Card-investor podcasts (Stacking Slabs and similar).
- Discord server presence (Loupe, specific breaker servers).

Tier 3 — Defer until product is proven

- Paid acquisition. Wastes money before product-market fit.
- PR / press.
- Partnerships with grading companies.

8.3 The Trade-Show Audience Caveat

Trade-show attendees skew toward hardcore hobbyists, not pure investors. Carson's field marketing reaches a real audience but not necessarily our highest-intent target. Mix trade-show research with online (card-Twitter, Reddit, Discord) to triangulate.

Open Questions — GTM

- What's the cheapest, fastest channel to find 20 paying users by month 6?
- What's the customer acquisition cost at each channel, once tested?
- Is there a paid distribution play (e.g., affiliate program for card creators) worth piloting once we have product?

9. Business Model

9.1 Working Revenue Model

Subscription SaaS. Two tiers (working hypothesis):

- Free tier: full comp lookup (sold and active listings) with limits — watchlist capped at approximately 5 cards, historical comp data restricted to the last 30 days. Designed as the top of the conversion funnel: gives users enough to feel the product's quality without supporting the use case of a serious investor managing a portfolio.
- Pro tier: the Buy/Hold/Sell Recommendation Engine (the v1 wedge, per Section 4.2), plus unlimited watchlist size and full historical comp data. Target pricing: $25-40/month or $250-400/year. The decision intelligence is what users pay for; comp lookup is the supporting infrastructure that's free as a top-of-funnel.

Pricing should land at or above Card Ladder ($200/yr) to position SlabMetrics as the serious-investor tool, not the cheap alternative. Final pricing to be validated with customer interviews and willingness-to-pay tests.

9.2 Why Subscription, Not Transactional

Marketplace revenue (transaction fees) requires being a marketplace, which we explicitly aren't. Affiliate revenue from eBay/etc. could be a future supplement but is too small and too dependent on partner whims to anchor the business model.

9.3 Unit Economics (Working Estimates)

These are placeholder estimates to be refined. They are not based on validated data.

- Estimated COGS per user/month: $2-5 (data costs, hosting, payment processing).
- Estimated LTV (gross) at $30/mo and 12-month avg retention: ~$360.
- Estimated CAC ceiling for healthy unit economics: ~$120 (LTV:CAC of 3:1).

Every number in this section is a guess at this stage. Replace with real data as available.

Open Questions — Business Model

- What price point maximizes revenue (not just adoption)? Test via willingness-to-pay conversations.
- Is there an enterprise/dealer tier worth offering at $200+/month?
- Does freemium make sense or does it cannibalize? Some categories suggest 'no freemium for investor tools' is the right call.

10. Operations and Team

10.1 Current Team

- Carson Froy — co-founder. Domains: card market expertise, brand, social, field marketing, customer research within the card community. Currently building personal investor expertise via decision-logging experiment.
- Kain Kim — co-founder. Domains: product, software engineering, infrastructure, digital marketing. Concurrent commitments: ownership of a North Georgia coffee roasting business.

10.2 Time Commitment

Both founders are sophomore-equivalent undergraduates at the University of Georgia. Time commitment is part-time during academic terms, full-time during summer and winter breaks. Founders' agreement uses objective-based milestones rather than weekly hour quotas, set quarterly.

This is a real constraint, not a footnote. A part-time pre-revenue team competing against full-time funded incumbents is at a structural disadvantage on raw output. Our advantage has to come from being right about what to build, not how much we build.

10.3 Capital Posture

Bootstrap for v1. Founders are not contributing required capital to the entity. Reimbursable business expenses are tracked and reimbursed from revenue before profit distribution (per founders' agreement § 4.3).

No outside capital has been raised. No outside capital is sought for v1. Conversations with potential advisors may begin once we have validated evidence from the 90-day experiment and customer research.

10.4 Legal Structure

Currently operating as an informal general partnership in Georgia. Both founders have signed a Founders' Agreement governing equity, vesting, roles, and IP. Intention to form a Georgia LLC within 6 months for liability protection and to formalize the legal entity.

Open Questions — Operations

- When do we actually file the Georgia LLC? Recommended within 60 days.
- Who's our first non-founder hire, if any, in year 1? Likely a part-time content / community contractor, not an engineer.
- Do we need an advisor with card-market depth? Almost certainly yes. Identify within 90 days.

11. Milestones — 12 Months

Q1 (May-Jul 2026)

- Founders' agreement signed. Decision-logging experiment running. eBay production access live.
- 130point and other comp data conversations completed.
- First 10 customer interviews with non-friend card investors.
- Signal validation complete: at end of 90-day experiment, founders have identified which of the five candidate signals (or which additional signals if the original five fail) have shown predictive value per the Section 4.2 failure criterion. The Buy/Hold/Sell Recommendation Engine v1 design is finalized around the validated signals.

Q2 (Aug-Oct 2026)

- Comp lookup v1 functional with real eBay data.
- Wedge feature v0 built and used internally.
- Total of 30+ customer interviews completed; profile refined.
- Closed beta with 5-10 hand-picked users.

Q3 (Nov 2026 - Jan 2027)

- Wedge feature v1 polished. Stripe integrated.
- Closed beta expanded to 15-20 users.
- First paying customer conversion (target: 5-10 by quarter end).
- Decision-logging experiment v2 launched with broader signal taxonomy.

Q4 (Feb-Apr 2027)

- Public launch. Subscription live.
- Target: 20+ paying users by end of month 12.
- Updated business plan written — outside-facing memo + pitch deck for advisor and investor conversations.

Milestones are ambitious for a part-time student founder team. Treat slippage of 1-2 months on any milestone as expected, not as failure. Treat slippage of 4+ months as a signal to reassess scope or capacity.

12. Risks

Listed roughly in order of likelihood-times-impact.

Risk 1 — Co-founder conflict or departure
The single largest startup-killer. Mitigation: founders' agreement with vesting, clear roles, dispute process. Re-read the agreement at each 6-month checkpoint.

Risk 2 — Building for users we don't understand
Both founders are early in their card-investor identity. Without customer-research discipline, we will build features that sound right but solve no real pain. Baseball amplifies this risk in v1 specifically: baseball card knowledge (parallels, prospect-card dynamics, vintage-vs-modern conventions, the role of Beckett vs. PSA) is meaningfully different from basketball and football, and neither founder has prior baseball depth. Mitigation: 30+ structured interviews including dedicated baseball-investor conversations; decision-logging experiment expanded to include real baseball positions for both founders within 30 days; identify a baseball-specific advisor within 90 days.

Risk 3 — Data access falls through
If Marketplace Insights API approval fails AND 130point pricing is unworkable, we have no comp data foundation. Mitigation: pursue both in parallel; explore other aggregators (CardCensus, MySlabs feeds) as backup.

Risk 4 — Card market contracts further
If the cards-as-investment thesis loses ground over 12-18 months, our target audience shrinks. Mitigation: build the product so it serves serious-hobbyist conversion targets too; don't bet everything on the pure-investor identity persisting.

Risk 5 — Incumbent competitive response
Card Ladder or CollX could ship a competing feature within 90 days of our launch. Mitigation: build decision intelligence features that combine multiple capabilities (e.g., comp data, grading expected-value math, condition assessment, and other analytical signals) in ways harder to replicate than a single UI change.

Risk 6 — Founder time and attention
Both founders have other commitments (school, coffee company, family). Mitigation: realistic milestones; objective-based agreement that doesn't pretend to extract 40-hour weeks from students.

Risk 7 — Premature scaling
Spending money on paid acquisition or hiring before product-market fit. Mitigation: explicit policy that paid acquisition stays off until we have at least 20 organically-acquired paying users with retention data.

13. What This Document Is Honestly Missing

In the spirit of a working document, here is what's not yet here and should be added as evidence develops:

- A real bottom-up TAM estimate.
- Validated customer research synthesis (currently we have anecdotes from friends, not structured research).
- Validated pricing (currently a guess based on competitive positioning, not willingness-to-pay data).
- Real unit economics (CAC, retention, churn) — these come from beta users, not before.
- Detailed financial projections — premature without real revenue or cost data.
- A founder-level vision for what SlabMetrics looks like in 5 years if it succeeds — to be developed before we ever pitch outside readers.

The Honest Frame
This document represents our best thinking as of May 2026, based on competitive analysis, founder discussion, and limited informal user conversations. It is intentionally honest about what is hypothesis vs. evidence. Our job over the next 90-180 days is to convert hypotheses into evidence, then rewrite this document accordingly.

Revision Log

Version	Date	Changes	Authors
0.1	May 2026	Initial draft. Working document for internal use. Built from strategy conversations between Carson, Kain, and an external thinking partner.	Carson Froy, Kain Kim